Outlook search not returning results

Article KB0010066 | Owner: Messaging & Collaboration | Subcategory: Outlook | Applies to: Outlook for Windows (Microsoft 365 Apps for enterprise) on Windows 11 23H2/24H2, Outlook for Mac (latest supported version) on macOS 14/15, Company-managed laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), Remote and office-based users accessing Exchange Online via Microsoft 365

Summary

Outlook search may stop returning results due to a corrupted local search index, disabled Windows Search service, or issues with the offline Outlook data file (.ost). This article guides users through basic troubleshooting and provides the Messaging & Collaboration team with a structured approach to rebuild the index and restore full search functionality.

Symptoms

- Search box returns "No items found" even when known messages exist
- Instant search yields empty results while browsing folders shows items
- Search indexing status in Outlook shows "Indexing incomplete" or "Indexing speed: reduced"
- Windows Search service appears stopped in Services MMC
- Outlook .ost file size exceeds typical limits (e.g., >50?GB) causing indexing slowdown

Common causes

- Corrupted or outdated Windows Search index for the Outlook data file
- Windows Search service disabled or set to manual start
- Large or damaged .ost/.pst file preventing proper indexing
- Third-party COM add-in interfering with Outlook's search subsystem
- Insufficient free disk space on the system drive where the index resides

Initial Checks

Before diving into a rebuild, perform a few quick checks that often resolve the issue without any configuration changes. Confirm that Outlook is connected to Exchange Online and not working offline; look at the bottom-right status bar for "Connected". Verify that the cursor in the search box actually accepts input and that the dropdown shows recent searches. Open the Windows Services console (services.msc) and ensure the "Windows Search" service is set to Automatic and is currently running. Finally, check available space on the C:\\, ensuring at least 10?GB free for the index to grow.

Self-Help Procedure (User)

If the initial checks do not restore search results, you can rebuild the Outlook search index yourself. This process recreates the local index used by Outlook and Windows Search, which often fixes corruption. It may take several minutes depending on mailbox size and disk speed; you can continue to work while it runs in the background.

1. Close Outlook completely (ensure no Outlook processes remain in Task Manager).
2. Press Win?+?S, type "Indexing Options", and open the control panel item.
3. Click Modify, then uncheck the box next to "Microsoft Outlook" (or the specific .ost file location shown). Click OK to remove Outlook from the index.
4. Still in Indexing Options, click Advanced, then under the Index Settings tab choose Rebuild. Confirm the warning and let Windows rebuild the index - this may take 10-30?minutes.
5. Once rebuilding completes, return to Indexing Options -> Modify and re-check the box for Microsoft Outlook to add it back to the index.
6. Restart Outlook and wait a few moments for the index to populate; then try a search for a known message or attachment to confirm results appear.

Advanced Checks

When the self-help steps do not resolve the problem, consider deeper causes such as faulty add-ins, a damaged Outlook profile, or policy restrictions that block indexing. These checks are safe to perform and can be done by the user or with light guidance from the service desk.

Service-Desk Agent Procedure

Follow this structured workflow when a user reports Outlook search not returning results and self-help has not succeeded. Use remote assistance tools (Teams screen share or Remote Help) to observe the user's environment and apply fixes systematically.

1. Verify the user's identity and confirm they are using a company-managed device with the latest Windows 11 build and Microsoft 365 Apps.
2. Check the Windows Search service status via services.msc; if stopped, set startup type to Automatic and start it.
3. Launch Indexing Options, confirm that Microsoft Outlook is included in the indexed locations; if not, add it.
4. Select Advanced -> Rebuild to recreate the search index; monitor progress and inform the user this may take several minutes.
5. If the index rebuild does not help, run ScanOST.exe (located in the Office installation folder) against the user's .ost file to repair any corruption.
6. Should ScanOST fail or the .ost be excessively large (>50?GB), guide the user to create a new Outlook profile via Control Panel -> Mail -> Show Profiles, then set the new profile as default and allow Outlook to resynchronize the mailbox.
7. Disable any non-essential COM add-ins temporarily (File -> Options -> Add-ins -> Manage COM Add-ins) and test search; re-enable add-ins one by one to identify a culprit.
8. After each major step, ask the user to perform a test search for a known item and confirm results appear before proceeding to the next action.

Verification

Once the search index is rebuilt or the profile recreated, verify that normal search behavior has returned and that the fix persists. Ask the user to conduct a few representative searches (by sender, subject, attachment name) and to check that results appear promptly. Document the final state in the ticket, close the incident, and advise the user to monitor for recurrence over the next 24?hours. If search fails again, escalate per the escalation guidance below.

When to escalate

If search remains unavailable after rebuilding the index, repairing the .ost, creating a new profile, and disabling add-ins, escalate to the Messaging & Collaboration team (owning group) with details: Outlook version, Windows build, size of .ost, steps already taken, screenshots of Indexing Options and any error messages, and whether the issue affects multiple users or is isolated.

Keywords: Outlook search not working, Outlook no search results, Instant search empty, Search indexing failed, Windows Search service, OST corruption, Rebuild index